Meeting of the Aristotelian Society at 21, *Bedford Square, London, W.C.*1, *on* 3*rd June*, 1957, *at* 7.30 *p.m.*

XIV.—INTENTION

By G. E. M. Anscombe

What distinguishes actions which are intentional from those which are not? The answer that suggests itself is that they are the actions to which a certain sense of the question 'Why?' is given application; the sense is defined as that in which the answer, *if positive*, gives a reason for acting. But this hardly gets us any further, because the questions 'What is the relevant sense of the question "Why?"' and 'What is meant by "reason for acting"?' are one and the same.

To see the difficulties here, consider the question 'Why did you knock the cup off the table?' answered by 'I thought I saw a face at the window and it made me jump.' Now we cannot say that since the answer mentions something previous to the action, this will be a cause as opposed to a reason; for if you ask 'Why did you kill him?' the answer 'he killed my father' is surely a reason rather than a cause, but what it mentions is previous to the action. It is true that we don't ordinarily think of a case like giving a sudden start when we speak of a *reason for acting*. 'Giving a sudden start', someone might say, 'is not *acting* in the sense suggested by the expression "reason for acting".' Hence, though indeed we readily say *e.g.* 'What was the reason for your starting so violently?' this is totally unlike 'What is your reason for excluding so-and-so from your will?' or 'What is your reason for sending for a taxi?' But what *is* the difference? Why is giving a start or gasp not an 'action', while sending for a taxi or crossing the road is one? The answer cannot be 'Because an answer to the question "why?" may give a reason in the latter cases', for the answer may 'give a reason' in the former cases too; and

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we cannot say 'Ah, but not a *reason for acting*;' we should be going round in circles. We need to find the difference between the two kinds of 'reason' without talking about 'acting'; and if we do, perhaps we shall discover what is meant by 'acting' when it is said with this special emphasis.

It will hardly be enlightening to say 'in the case of the sudden start the "reason" is a *cause*'; the topic of causality is in a state of too great confusion; all we know is that this is one of the places where we do use the word 'cause'. But we also know that this is rather a strange case of causality; the subject is able to give a cause of a thought or feeling or bodily movement in the same kind of way as he is able to state the place of his pain or the position of his limbs. Such statements are not based on observation.

Nor can we say: 'Well, the "reason" for a movement is a cause, and not a reason in the sense of "reason for acting", when the movement is involuntary; it is a reason as opposed to a cause, when the movement is voluntary and intentional.' This is partly because in any case the object of the whole enquiry is really to delineate such concepts as the voluntary and the intentional, and partly because one can also give a 'reason' which is only a 'cause' for what is voluntary and intentional. *E.g.* 'Why are you walking up and down like that?'—'It's that military band; it excites me.' Or 'What made you sign the document at last?'—'The thought: "It is my duty" kept hammering away in my mind until I said to myself "I can do no other", and so signed.'

Now we can see that the cases where this difficulty arises are just those where the cause itself, *qua* cause, (or perhaps one should rather say the causation itself) is in the class of things known without observation.

I will call the type of cause in question a '*mental cause*'. Mental causes are possible, not only for actions ('The martial music excites me, that is why I walk up and down') but

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also for feelings and even thoughts. In considering actions, it is important to distinguish between mental causes and motives; in considering feelings, such as fear or anger, it is important to distinguish between mental causes and objects of feeling. To see this, consider the following cases:

A child saw a bit of red stuff on a turn in a stairway and asked what it was. He thought his nurse told him it was a bit of Satan and felt dreadful fear of it. (No doubt she said it was a bit of satin.) What he was frightened of was the bit of stuff; the cause of his fright was his nurse's remark. The object of fear may be the cause of fear, but, as Wittgenstein[1] remarks, is not *as such* the cause of fear. (A hideous face appearing at the window would of course be both cause and object, and hence the two are easily confused.) Or again, you may be angry *at* someone's action, when what makes you angry is some reminder of it, or someone's telling you of it.

This sort of cause of a feeling or reaction may be reported by the person himself, as well as recognised by someone else, even when it is not the same as the object. Note that this sort of causality or sense of 'causality' is so far from accommodating itself to Hume's explanations that people who believe that Hume pretty well dealt with the topic of causality would entirely leave it out of their calculations; if their attention were drawn to it they might insist that the word 'cause' was inappropriate or was quite equivocal. Or conceivably they might try to give a Humeian account of the matter as far as concerned the outside observer's recognition of the cause; but hardly for the patient's.

Now one might think that when the question 'Why?' is answered by giving the intention with which a person acts—a case of which I will here simply characterise by

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[1] *Philosophical Investigations*, § 476.

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saying that it mentions something future—this is also a case of a mental cause. For couldn't it be recast in the form: 'Because I wanted . . .' or 'Out of a desire that . . .'? If a feeling of desire for an apple affects me and I get up and go to a cupboard where I think there are some, I might answer the question what led to this action by mentioning the desire as having made me . . . *etc.* But it is not in all cases that 'I did so and so in order to . . .' can be backed up by 'I *felt* a desire that . . .' I may *e.g.* simply hear a knock on the door and go downstairs to open it without experiencing any such desire. Or suppose I feel an upsurge of spite against someone and destroy a message he has received so that he shall miss an appointment. If I describe this by saying 'I wanted to make him miss that appointment', this does not necessarily mean that I had the thought 'If I do this, he will . . .' and that it affected me with a desire of bringing that about which led up to my action. This may have happened, but need not. It could be that all that happened was this: I read the message, had the thought 'That unspeakable man!' with feelings of hatred, tore the message up, and laughed. Then if the question 'Why did you do that?' is put by someone who makes it clear that he wants me to mention the mental causes—*i.e.*, what went on in my mind and issued in the action—I should perhaps give this account; but normally the reply would be no such thing. That particular enquiry is not very often made. Nor do I wish to say that it always has an answer in cases where it can be made. One might shrug or say 'I don't know that there was any definite history of the kind you mean', or 'It merely occurred to me . . .'

A 'mental cause', of course, need not be a mental event, *i.e.*, a thought or feeling or image; it might be a knock on the door. But if it is not a mental event, it must be something perceived by the person affected—*e.g.* the knock on the door must be heard—so if in this sense anyone wishes to say it is always a mental event, I have no objection. A mental cause is what someone would describe if he were asked the specific question: what produced this action or

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thought or feeling in you? *i.e.,* what did you see or hear or feel, or what ideas or images cropped up in your mind, and led **up** to it? I have isolated this notion of a mental cause because there *is* such a thing as this question with this sort of answer, and because I want to distinguish it from the ordinary senses of ' motive ' and 'intention', rather than because it is **in** itself of very great importance; for I believe that it is of very little. But it is important to have a clear idea of it, partly because *a* very natural conception of ' motive' is that it is what *moves* (the very word suggests that)-glossed as ' what *causes* ' a man's actions *etc.* **And** ' what causes ' them is perhaps then thought of as an event that brings the effect about-though *how-i.e.* whether it should be thought of as a kind of pushing in another medium, or in some other way-is of course completely obscure.

In philosophy a distinction has sometimes been drawn between ' motives' and ' intentions in acting' as referring to quite different things. A man's intention is *what* he aims at or chooses; his motive is what determines the aim or choice; and I suppose that ' determines ' must here be another word for ' causes '.

Popularly, ' motive ' and ' intention ' are not treated as so distinct in meaning. *E.g.* we hear of 'the motive of gain '; some philosophers have wanted to say that such an expression must be elliptical; gain must be the *intention,* and *desire* of *gain* the motive. Asked for a motive, a man might say' I wanted to . . . 'which would please such philosophers; or '**I** did it in order to . . . ' which would not; and yet the meaning of the two phrases is here identical. When a man's motives are called good, this may be in no way distinct from calling his intentions *good-e.g.* ' he only wanted to make peace among his relations '.

Nevertheless there is even popularly a distinction between the meaning of ' motive ' and the meaning of 'intention'. *E.g.* if a man kills someone, he may be said to have done it out of love and pity, or to have done it out of hatred; these might indeed be cast in the forms' to release

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him from this awful suffering ', or ' to get rid of the swine '; but though these are forms of expression suggesting objectives, they are perhaps expressive of the spirit in which the man killed rather than descriptive of the end to which the killing was a means—a future state of affairs to be produced by the killing. And this shows us part of the distinction that there is between the popular senses of motive and intention. We should say: popularly, ' motive for an action ' has a rather wider and more diverse application than ' intention with which the action was done '.

When a man says what his motive was, speaking popularly, and in a sense in which ' motive ' is not interchangeable with ' intention ', he is not giving a ' mental cause ' in the sense that I have given to that phrase. The fact that the mental causes were such-and-such may indeed help to make his claim intelligible. And further, though he may say that his motive was this or that one straight off and without lying—*i.e.* without saying what he knows or even half knows to be untrue—yet a consideration of various things, which may include the mental causes, might possibly lead both him and other people to judge that his declaration of his own motive was false. But it appears to me that the mental causes are seldom more than a very trivial item among the things that it would be reasonable to consider. As for the importance of considering the motives of an action, as opposed to considering the intention, I am very glad not to be writing either ethics or literary criticism, to which this question belongs.

Motives may explain actions to us; but that is not to say that they ' determine ', in the sense of causing, actions. We do say: ' His love of truth caused him to . . . ' and similar things, and no doubt such expressions help us to think that a motive must be what produces or brings about a choice. But this means rather ' He did this in that he loved the truth '; it interprets his action.

Someone who sees the confusions involved in radically distinguishing between motives and intentions and in defining motives, so distinct, as the determinants of choice,

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may easily be inclined to deny both that there is any such thing as mental causality, and that ' motive ' means anything but intention. But both of these inclinations are mistaken. We shall create confusion if we do not notice (*a*) that phenomena deserving the name of mental causality exist, for we can make the question ' Why? ' into a request for the sort of answer that I considered under that head; (*b*) that mental causality is not restricted to choices or voluntary or intentional actions but is of wider application; it is restricted to the wider field of things the agent knows about *not* as an observer, so that it includes some involuntary actions; (*c*) that motives are not mental causes; and (*d*) that there is application for ' motive ' other than the applications of ' the intention with which a man acts '.

Revenge and gratitude are motives; if I kill a man as an act of revenge I may say I do it in order to be revenged, or that revenge is my object; but revenge is not some further thing obtained by killing him, it is rather that killing him is revenge. Asked why I killed him, I reply ' Because he killed my brother.' We might compare this answer, which describes a concrete past event, to the answer describing a concrete future state of affairs which we sometimes get in statements of objectives. It is the same with gratitude, and remorse, and pity for something specific. These motives differ from, say, love or curiosity or despair in just this way: something that *has happened* (or is at present happening) is given as the ground of an action or abstention that is good or bad for the person (it may be oneself, as with remorse) at whom it is aimed. And if we wanted to explain *e.g.* revenge, we should say it was harming someone because he had done one some harm; we should not need to add some description of the feelings prompting the action or of the thoughts that had gone with it. Whereas saying that someone does something out of, say, friendship cannot be explained in any such way. I will call revenge and gratitude and remorse and pity backward-looking motives, and contrast them with motive-in-general.

Motive-in-general is a very difficult topic which I do

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not want to discuss at any length. Consider the statement that one motive for my signing a petition was admiration for its promoter, X. Asked 'Why did you sign it?' I might well say 'Well, for one thing, X, who is promoting it, did . . .' and describe what he did in an admiring way. I might add 'Of course, I know that is not a ground for signing it, but I am sure it was one of the things that most influenced me'—which need *not* mean: 'I thought explicitly of this before signing.' I say 'Consider this' really with a view to saying 'let us not consider it here.' It is too complicated. The account of motive popularised by Professor Ryle does not appear satisfactory. He recommends construing 'he boasted from vanity' as saying 'he boasted . . . and his doing so satisfies the law-like proposition that whenever he finds a chance of securing the admiration and envy of others, he does whatever he thinks will produce this admiration and envy.'[2] This passage is rather curious and roundabout in its way of putting what it seems to say, but I can't understand it unless it implies that a man could not be said to have boasted from vanity unless he always behaved vainly, or at least very often did so. But this does not seem to be true.

To give a motive (of the sort I have labelled 'motive-in-general', as opposed to backward-looking motives and intentions) is to say something like 'See the action in this light.' To explain one's own actions by an account indicating a motive is to put them in a certain light. This sort of explanation is often elicited by the question 'Why?' The question whether the light in which one so puts one's action is a true light is a notoriously difficult one.

The motives admiration, curiosity, spite, friendship, fear, love of truth, despair and a host of others are either of this extremely complicated kind, or are forward-looking or mixed. I call a motive forward-looking if it is an intention. For example, to say that someone did something for fear

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[2] *The Concept of Mind*, p. 89.

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of . . . often comes to the same as saying he did so lest . . . or in order that . . . should not happen.

Leaving then, the topic of motive-in-general or 'interpretative' motive, let us return to backward-looking motives. Why is it that in revenge and gratitude, pity and remorse, the past event (or present situation) is a reason for acting, not just a mental cause?

Now the most striking thing about these four is the way in which good and evil are involved in them. *E.g.* if I am grateful to someone, it is because he has done me some good, or at least I think he has, and I cannot show gratitude by something that I intend to harm him. In remorse, I hate some good things for myself; I could not express remorse *by* getting myself plenty of enjoyments, or *for* something that I did not find bad. If I do something out of revenge which is in fact advantageous rather than harmful to my enemy, my action, in its description of being advantageous to him, is involuntary.

These facts are the clue to our present problem. If an action has to be thought of by the agent as doing good or harm of some sort, and the thing in the past as good or bad, in order for the thing in the past to be the reason for the action, then this reason shows not a mental cause but a motive. This will come out in the agent's elaborations on his answer to the question 'Why?'

It might seem that this is not the most important point, but that the important point is that a *proposed* action can be questioned and the answer be a mention of something past. 'I am going to kill him.'—'Why?'—'He killed my father.' But do we yet know what a proposal to act is; other than a prediction which the predictor justifies, if he does justify it, by mentioning a reason for acting? and the meaning of the expression 'reason for acting' is precisely what we are at present trying to elucidate. Might one not predict mental causes and their effects? Or even their effects after the causes have occurred? *E.g.* 'This is going to make me angry.' Here it may be worth while to remark that it is a mistake to think one cannot choose whether to act from a

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motive. Plato saying to a slave ' I should beat you if I were not angry ' would be a case. Or a man might have a policy of never making remarks about a certain person because he could not speak about that man unenviously or unadmiringly.

We have now distinguished between a backward-looking motive and a mental cause, and found that here at any rate what the agent reports in answer to the question ' Why? ' is a reason-for-acting if, in treating it as a reason, he conceives it as something good or bad, and his own action as doing good or harm. If you could *e.g.* show that either the action for which he has revenged himself, or that in which he has revenged himself, was quite harmless or beneficial, he ceases to offer a reason, except prefaced by ' I thought '. If it is a proposed revenge he either gives it up or changes his reasons. No such discovery would affect an assertion of mental causality. Whether in general good and harm play an essential part in the concept of intention is something it still remains to find out. So far good and harm have only been introduced as making a clear difference between a backward-looking motive and a mental cause. When the question ' Why? ' about a present action is answered by description of a future state of affairs, this is already distinguished from a mental cause just by being future. Here there does not so far seem to be any need to characterise intention as being essentially of good or of harm.

Now, however, let us consider this case:

> Why did you do it?
> Because he told me to.

Is this a cause or a reason? It appears to depend very much on what the action was or what the circumstances were. And we should often refuse to make any distinction at all between something's being a reason and its being a cause of the kind in question; for that was explained as what one is after if one asks the agent what led up to and issued in an action, but being given a reason and accepting it might be

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such a thing. And how would one distinguish between cause and reason in such a case as having hung one's hat on a peg because one's host said 'Hang up your hat on that peg'? Nor, I think, would it be correct to say that this is a reason and not a mental cause because of the understanding of the words that went into obeying the suggestion. Here one would be attempting a contrast between this case and, say, turning round at hearing someone say Boo! But this case would not in fact be decisively on one side or the other; forced to say whether the noise was a reason or a cause, one would probably decide by how sudden one's reaction was. Further, there is no question of understanding a sentence in the following case: 'Why did you waggle your two fore-fingers by your temples?'—'Becasue *he* was doing it;' but this is not particularly different from hanging one's hat up because one's host said 'Hang your hat up.' Roughly speaking, if one were forced to go on with the distinction, the more the action is described as a mere response, the more inclined one would be to the word 'cause'; while the more it is described as a response to something as having a *significance* that is dwelt on by the agent, or as a response surrounded with thoughts and questions, the more inclined one would be to use the word 'reason'. But in very many cases the distinction would have no point.

This, however, does not mean that it never has a point. The cases on which we first grounded the distinction might be called 'full-blown': that is to say, the case of *e.g.* revenge on the one hand, and of the thing that made me jump and knock a cup off a table on the other. Roughly speaking, it establishes something as a reason to object to it, not as when one says 'Noises should not make you jump like that: hadn't you better see a doctor?' but in such a way as to link it up with motives and intentions. 'You did it because he told you to? But why do what he says?' Answers like 'he has done a lot for me'; 'he is my father'; 'it would have been the worse for me if I hadn't' give the original answer a place among reasons. Thus the full-blown

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cases are the right ones to consider in order to see the distinction between reason and cause. But it is worth noticing that what is so commonly said, that reason and cause are everywhere sharply distinct notions, is not true.

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